

Vitamin B12 in the Diet

Sources and Importance for Vegetarians

Vitamin B12 is a water-soluble vitamin required for nerve function, red blood cell production, and DNA synthesis. It is found naturally in animal products. Vegetarians and vegans are at higher risk of low intake and may need fortified foods or supplements.

Why B12 Matters

Vitamin B12 plays a central role in maintaining the protective coating of nerves and in producing healthy red blood cells. Low levels can lead to fatigue, tingling in the hands and feet, and, over time, nerve damage. The body stores several years' worth of B12 in the liver, so deficiencies develop slowly.

Food Sources

B12 is found in meat, fish, eggs, and dairy. Plant foods do not contain B12 unless they are fortified. Common fortified foods include nutritional yeast, some plant milks, and some breakfast cereals.

Suggested Items:

- Eggs - approximately 0.6 mcg per egg
- Milk - approximately 1 mcg per cup
- Curd (yogurt) - approximately 1 mcg per cup
- Fortified nutritional yeast - up to 8 mcg per tablespoon
- Fortified plant milks - varies by brand, often 1 mcg per cup
- Fortified breakfast cereals - varies by brand

Food	B12 (mcg)	Serving
Egg	0.6	1 large
Milk	1.0	1 cup
Curd	1.0	1 cup
Nutritional yeast	8.0	1 tbsp
Fortified plant milk	1.0	1 cup

Conclusion

Vegetarians, especially vegans, should have their B12 status checked periodically. A qualified health professional can advise on supplements if dietary intake is inadequate.